

wards for UPI transactions will also be essential.

QR set-up: The other challenge is that card penetration is very high in most countries that Indians visit—like the US, UK, UAE, Singapore and Thailand. So, setting up a QR-based network will be a daunting task. “Merchant acceptance of QR will also need some legwork in these countries, as the domestic real-time payment networks compete with cards in these markets,” says Talukdar.

Gandhi adds, “It will probably take a year or two to smoothen the global payments process. And implementation will take time because all the banks have to accept the tech integration. They must ensure that QR codes are accepted at all merchant locations.”

24 | Lobbying and geopolitics: In developed economies, where cards are the primary mode of payment, UPI adoption might take a while as it may face opposition from incumbents. Satya-jeet Kunjeer, Founder and CEO of investment app Deciml, says, “Companies like MasterCard, Visa and banks alike will not welcome this move as it directly impacts their revenue. Also, in countries like the US, where lobbying is legal, we could see banks and payment gateways create serious barriers to entry.”

But Gandhi points out that memoranda of understanding (MoUs) have been signed with some countries. “I think NPCI has to [ensure] universality and, in short, that all the banks of [the foreign] country accept UPI payments and vice versa in India. There has to be reciprocity (an interchange) between UPI transactions and that country’s faster payment transactions in India. So, there has to be reciprocity of acceptance,” says Gandhi. **BT**

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HEALTHCARE

Specialised Play

With investment plans of \$400-500 million in the next five years, AHH is doubling down on its single specialty healthcare business

BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA

► **BENGALURU-BASED** healthcare investment platform Asia Healthcare Holdings (AHH) is planning to double its investments in the single specialty healthcare businesses to \$400-500 million in the next five years. Backed by private equity fund TPG Growth and Singapore’s sovereign wealth fund GIC, the company aims to focus on areas like oncology, women’s

and child healthcare, IVF and ophthalmology. Now, it plans to address the prevailing demand-supply gaps in other segments with these investments. “These investments will lead to the growth and development of specialised healthcare services and foster innovation and clinical expertise in the country,” says Mohit Khullar, MD at investment bank o3 Capital.

Apart from investing in India-based single specialty healthcare businesses, Bali says the platform will also look to invest in foreign firms that offer bolt-on services that complement its India businesses. It has also been exploring opportunities in the pathology diagnostics space. Bali believes that incorporating its own pathology services company—despite the sector’s disruption revolving around pricing—into the larger AHH ecosystem will significantly enhance the platform’s capabilities. “Pathology is not just about price disruption; it also involves technology advancements and the development of a new ecosystem to enhance disease detection and treatment,” he says. Further, in terms of growth prospects, the company anticipates revenues to be in the range of \$175-185 million for FY24, with a margin of around 20 per cent. **BT**

**\$200
million**

**AHH HAS DEPLOYED
THIS AMOUNT IN
THREE SINGLE
SPECIALTY FIRMS**

and children’s healthcare, and advanced tech in ICUs. AHH is also exploring opportunities in gastroenterology, nephrology, pathology diagnostics, etc.

“We are focussed on bringing additional specialties onto the AHH platform and aim to onboard one or two more companies. We have already deployed \$200 million behind three single specialty companies and expect to double this over the next five years,” says Vishal Bali, Executive Chairman of AHH. AHH has already invested in cancer care, mother

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